Baseball, Boys and Bad Words

By Andy Andrews

ANDY: In a town without a movie theater or fast-food restaurant, life is divided into three distinct seasons: football, basketball, and baseball. Time itself revolves around children, their practices, and games. Most kids played all three sports, but at 11 I didn't weigh enough to play football and measurements for basketball had me at a lofty 4'5". It was baseball for me and had been for several years.

One could easily pick out the kids from last year's team: Lee Peyton, Steve Krotzer, Phillip Wilson, Charles Raymond Floyd, and, of course, me. We all had on last year's hats. They were off-white with a dark-blue bill and a big "FNB" on the front. We knew that First National Bank, our sponsor, would be giving everyone new hats, but in the meantime, we wanted to be sure that our new coach could tell the veterans from the rookies.

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INTRODUCTION

In 1938, a man named Carl Stotz had the idea for an organized baseball league for the boys in his hometown of Williamsport, Pennsylvania. From those humble beginnings, Little League has become the world's largest organized youth sports program, creating new opportunities for girls to play baseball and softball, expanding play for teenage players, and initiating new programs to bring baseball and softball to children with physical and intellectual challenges.

In 1970, eleven-year-old Andy Andrews and a group of friends began a Little League season they would never forget. All the usual ingredients were there—well-worn gloves, freshly cut grass, and new uniforms. But the addition of a coach who was "new to the area" made this season truly unforgettable.

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ANDY: None of us had met our new coach. His name was Mr. Simpson. He was, we were told, "new to the area." "New to the area," was a hint that this person was "from the North." Living in the southern part of Alabama, the phrase brought visions of Vikings and pillaging to my mind. I had been told more than once that these people could be nice, but they were ***different*** -- articulated with a pause and with eyebrows raised.

Mr. Simpson parked his station wagon and gathered the equipment from the back. We watched him from the backstop as if he were some wild animal at the zoo. We noticed a boy with him -- red hair and more freckles than I had seen on any human since my Aunt Nancy Jane! The boy, we figured, was the coach's son since Mr. Simpson also had red hair and more than his share of freckles.

MR. SIMPSON: Hi, boys. My name is Hankin Simpson, and I'm your new coach. This is my son, Hankin Jr. Boys, I'm new to the area, but I'm sure that it's going to be a great season. Okay? Okay! Now, before we begin to practice, take a ***rap***!

ANDY: We shuffled our feet and looked at each other. *What did he want us to do? Take a what?* A ***rap***? What was a ***rap***? Hankin Jr. had begun to trot around the field, and figuring that he knew what he was doing, we trotted after him.

PHILLIP: *(with an air of superiority)* *"**Rap**"* is a Northern word. It means “to run.”

ANDY: I wasn't sure whether to believe him or not. Phillip Wilson was what 5-year-olds called a storyteller, what we called a fibber, and what adults called a liar. He could

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look you right in the eye, tell you a fib, and be so convincing that you never doubted a word he said.

Back at home plate, out of breath from running a ***rap***, we gathered around Mr. Simpson, quite sure that he would now assign positions. We veterans, a virtual sea of FNBs, silently pleading with the man not to look at one of us and say, "Right field."

Since time began, all Little Leaguers have had a fear of right field. In the glamour department, right field ranks dead last. Most batters are right-handed and hit the ball to left field; therefore, a coach who wants to avoid long losing streaks will put his weakest player in "right."

I'd had my brush with this humiliation two years earlier as the weak link for Henley's Hardware Store (green hat, white H). I couldn't catch, but I wasn't stupid. A permanent residence in right field was an embarrassment -- a curse. I was certain that I had been branded for the rest of my life. I could imagine myself as a grown-up going to a job interview and being told:

INTERVIEWER: *(with disdain)* We're sorry, but there's just no place for you at NASA. We see on your record that

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you played right field.

MR. SIMPSON: Boys, we're going to be winners this year. I'm excited about this team. Don't worry if you're new to the game. On my team everyone gets to ***pray***."

ANDY: *Excuse me? Did he say "pray."*

MR. SIMPSON: I know this is just practice, but I want you to ***pray*** your hearts out!

ANDY: *This team is in trouble.* Either someone had told our new leader that we lost 17 of 23 games last year, or he took one look at us and decided that we were a bunch of rejects. Mr. Simpson had settled on prayer as our only hope.

We practiced hard that first day: dove for grounders, swung for the fence, and generally showed as much hustle as we could muster. We didn't seem to be a vastly improved team from the year before. I blew a sure double play, our new pitcher was throwing the ball over the backstop, and Charles Raymond got hit in the head by a pop fly and cried.

It was at the end of practice, during the compulsory pep talk, when everything became crystal clear.

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MR. SIMPSON: There is one thing about this game you can count on. If you don't ***rearn*** to watch the ***basebarr*** hit the ***basebarr*** grove, you ***wirr*** never be an ***excerrent basebarr prayer***.

ANDY: We suddenly understood. A ***rap***? ***Pray*** hard? He had wanted us to take a ***lap****!* He had wanted us to ***play*** hard! From the depths of a pep talk to which no one was listening -- like a bolt from the blue -- those weird words all came together and made sense. Coach Simpson could not say his Ls! We could scarcely contain our collective excitement. To a group of 11-year-old boys, nothing beats having a human target at which to laugh. Double the fun if the boys are able to mimic the target, and triple if the unfortunate target happens to be an adult! *(characters speak mockingly with uncontrollable laughter during the following section)*

CHARLES RAYMOND: I'm a ***basebarr prayer***.

STEVE: No, you ain't. You're a right ***fierder***!

KEVIN: Take a ***rap***! Take a ***rap***!

PHILLIP: Did you hear him call me ***Phirrip***?

LEE: Coach Simpson? I ***rike*** him. I ***rearry*** do!

ANDY: To this day, Phillip Wilson is "***Phirrip***" to everyone

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who played on that team. And no one has forgotten the game that Lee Peyton rounded third, headed for home, and fell down laughing before he got there, because Coach Simpson really did yell, ***Sride, Ree! Sride!*** *(long beat)*

If I had to choose one time during that season to carry with me for the rest of my life, it would be the day Steve Krotzer got kicked off the team. Maybe kicked off is too harsh. Actually, he was transferred to another team, the Sand Dollar Shoes, because the league found out that Steve's family was living in another district. Steve had played with us for four years. He was our friend and a darn good first baseman. We didn't want him to leave. But that last day did arrive. When practice was over, Coach Simpson gathered us around the pitcher's mound.

MR. SIMPSON: Boys, this is a sad day. We're going to miss Steve. He's a fine ***barr*** prayer and a fine young man.

ANDY: Steve was close to tears. We were too.

MR. SIMPSON: I don't understand the inner workings of the system. But I do know one thing . . . and ***rook*** at me when I say this because it is important. I want every one

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of you to know that this was not Steve's ***faurt***. *(stifled giggling)*

ANDY: Did he say what we thought he said? Surely not.

MR. SIMPSON: This was not Steve's ***faurt***.

ANDY: Yes, he did most definitely, absolutely say what we thought he said! Oh sure, we knew what he meant; we'd been unconsciously translating Simpsonisms all year. He was telling us that it wasn't Steve's ***fault*** . . . but that wasn't what we were hearing! Of all the words in the world guaranteed to make 11-year-old boys laugh, only one of them is all by itself at the top of the list. And our coach -- an adult -- was saying that word over and over.

MR. SIMPSON: So don't pin the ***faurt*** on any one person, because it is just not their ***faurt***!

ANDY: *(silent giggling, to the point of tears)* I am not exaggerating when I say that we were literally crying. Coach Simpson became concerned. He sounded desperate as he tried to comfort us, but the more he explained that it wasn't our "***faurt***," the more out of hand things became. *(long beat with a smile brought on by the memory)*

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I haven't seen Coach Simpson in years. Kevin Perkins and Steve Krotzer were in my wedding. Lee Peyton went to medical school and returned to practice in our town. Charles Raymond Floyd was a late bloomer. He was a center fielder in college and played three years of minor league ball. I've totally lost track of Phillip Wilson. The last I heard, he was a used car salesman and perpetually campaigning for mayor in a small town in Louisiana.

I still remember us all as we were that summer. I can close my eyes and hear the explosions of laughter as we react to something that was, to us, the funniest thing in the world.

MR. SIMPSON: I want every one of you to know that this was not Steve's ***faurt***.

ANDY: And I feel a little sad when I think that when we were eleven years old, we may have laughed harder than we ever would again.

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